BUILD QUEUE 166 · DESIGN FOR YOUR APPROVAL · 14 OCTOBER 2026 · NOTHING IS BUILT YET

Symbol Sentence Writer

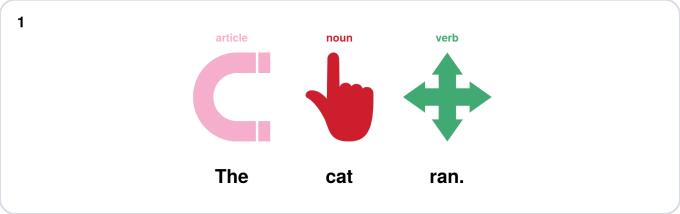
A new kind of question set where students type. It uses your 43 symbol sentences and walks each student up a ladder: first they type one missing word, and at the top they write whole sentences of their own.

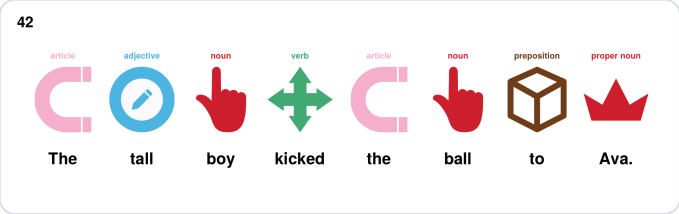
> *"lets make a new feature for question sets where students will have to have a text input. my goal is that students will be scaffolded, starting with filling in one word of a sentence, and working their way up to having full sentences created by them. we are going to use my symbol sentences. lets fully develop this before you build it at all"*

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1. What you gave me

43 sentences, from "The cat ran." to "The tall boy kicked the ball to Ava.", each with its row of symbols. There are three versions: a reference list, cards with the example words, and cards with symbols only.





Ten kinds of words, each with its own symbol and color. I cut each symbol cleanly out of your cards so the app can use them:

article · noun · proper noun · pronoun · verb · adjective · adverb · preposition · conjunction · interjection

Two things I noticed. Sentences 1 to 33 are the same deck that is already in the Grammar Sandbox as Symbol Sentences, and 34 to 43 are new (they bring in proper nouns). These cards also use new symbols: the old ones were colored Montessori shapes, and these are icons (a magnet, a pointing hand, arrows), plus a new crown for proper nouns. Question 1 at the end asks which symbols you want.

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2. The big idea: two ladders

Every question shows one of your sentences as its row of symbols, and the student types into it. Two things change as a student grows. They change separately, so you can see exactly where each student is.

The help ladder (8 levels)
How much of the sentence is already written. It starts with one missing word and ends with whole sentences they write themselves. Section 3 has every level.

The sentence path (your 43, in order)
How long and how tricky the sentence is: 3 words (#1) up to 9 or more words with joining words (#19). Pronoun cards (#22 to #30) and proper noun cards (#34 to #43) are short, so they come in early too.

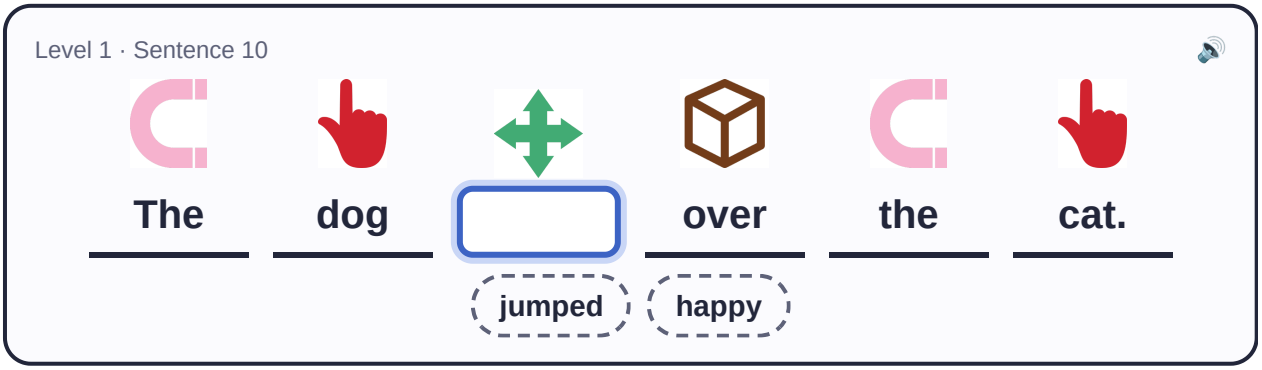
A student moves up a help level after **4 of their last 5 answers are right on the first try**. After **3 misses in a row**, the screen offers a step back down, and the student chooses (it is never forced). You can set each student's starting level and highest level, and lock a level.

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3. The help ladder, level by level

Mock-ups use card 10, "The dog jumped over the cat." Blue boxes are where the student types. On the real screen every symbol reads its name aloud when tapped, and 🔊 reads the whole sentence in a human voice.

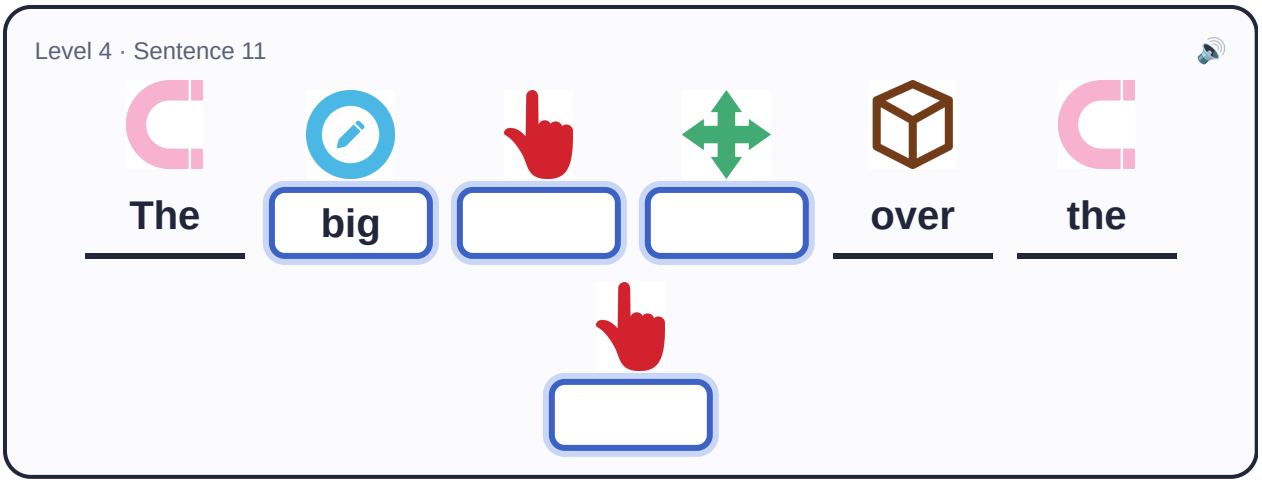
1 **One word, with a helper.** The whole sentence is there except one word. Two word cards sit underneath, and the student types the right one (they type it, not tap it). The wrong card is a different kind of word, so the symbol is what tells them which one fits.



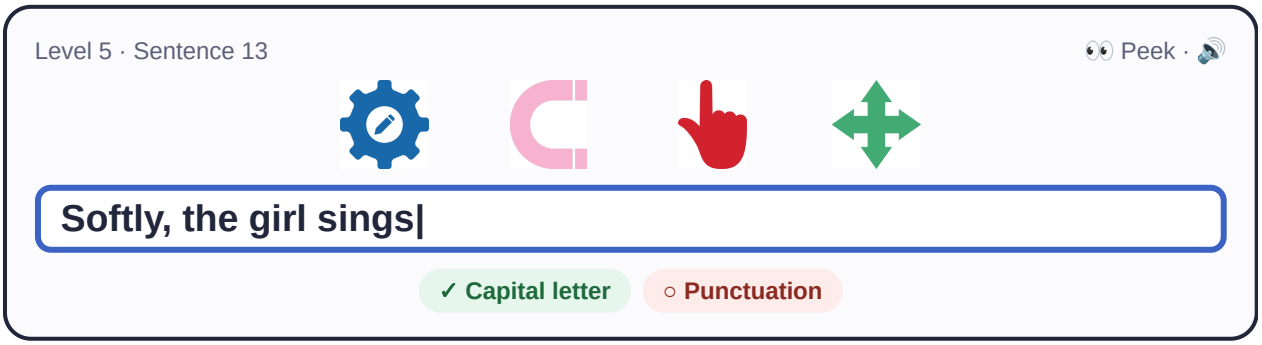
2 **One word, on your own.** The same sentence with no word cards. The symbol is the only clue: "This one moves, so it needs an action word." Any word of the right kind that makes sense counts (see question 2).

3 **Two words.** Two blanks, usually a noun and its verb, or an adjective and its noun.

4 **Every naming, action and describing word.** Small words like the articles, "and" and "over" stay written in. The student fills in every noun, verb, adjective and adverb.

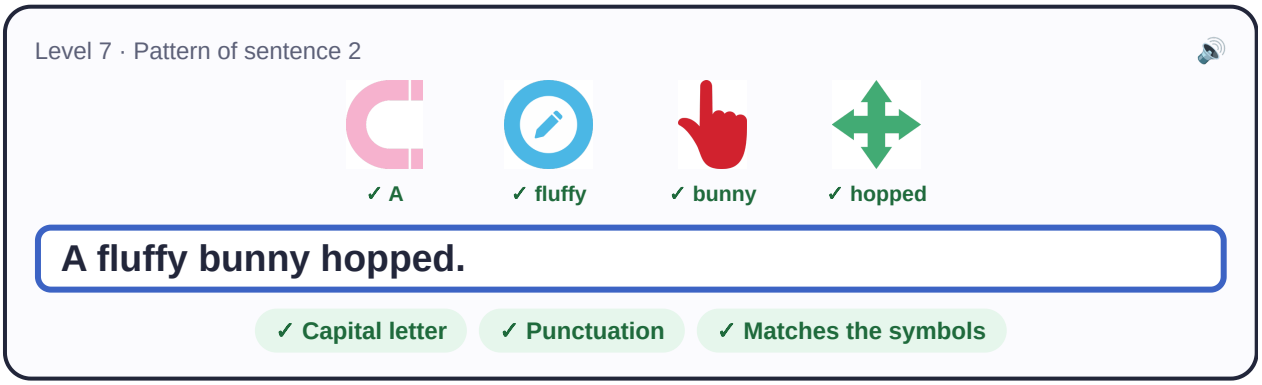


5 **Look, cover, write.** The whole sentence shows for a few seconds and then hides. The student types the whole sentence in one box. 👀 Peek shows it again (peeking is fine, it just does not count as first try). From this level on, the capital letter and punctuation are part of the answer, and two checks light up as they type.



6 **The whole sentence from the symbols, with word helpers.** Only the symbols show. Under each one is a small bank of words that fit. The student writes the whole sentence in order.

7 **My own sentence from the symbols.** Only the symbols show, and the student writes their own sentence that matches them. As they type, each word lights up under the symbol it matches, so they can see their own grammar.



8	**My own sentence, then I pick the symbols.** No symbols at the start. The student writes any sentence, then taps a symbol for each word (the reverse of level 7). This is the top of the ladder: they are writing full sentences of their own and showing that they know their grammar.

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4. When a student types

What happens	What the student sees and hears
Right on the first try	A cheer, the word glows in its symbol's color, and the sentence is read back in a human voice.
Small spelling slip	Counts as right, with a gentle note: "Almost! It is spelled **jumped**." (see question 3)
Wrong kind of word	"That is a describing word. This symbol needs an action word: something you can do." The symbol wiggles and reads its name.
Second try	A first-letter hint appears (j___).
Third try	The answer is shown and the student copies it. This is errorless: everyone finishes every sentence. It counts as effort, not first try.
Capital letter and punctuation	From level 5, two checks light up as they type. If one is missing on Done, the screen says which one, using your words: "Start with a capital letter." "End with punctuation."

Following Claudia's standard, effort is rewarded and not only first-try accuracy, nothing is ever compared with other students, and every miss is private.

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5. iPad first

- The iPad keyboard covers the bottom half of the screen, so the symbols and typing boxes sit in the top half and stay visible.
- **Auto-capitalize, autocorrect and spell check are turned off in these boxes.** Capital letters and spelling are the skill being practiced, so the iPad must not do them for the student.
- The keyboard's Next key moves to the next box. Big boxes, big text, and the dyslexia font works here too.
- Read-aloud on everything: each symbol's name, the sentence, the hints. Human voices only, as you asked.
- Optional 🎤 say it, then type it (the same "say it first, then copy your words" idea from the Creature Maker). You decide per student (question 5).

6. Your side (teacher)

Making a set

- A new set type in Question Sets: "✍️ Symbol Sentence Writer".
- All 43 of your sentences come preloaded. You tick which ones to use, or "use all, in order".
- Choose which help levels the set covers (for example only 1 to 3).
- Add your own sentence: type it, the app suggests a symbol for every word, and you fix any that are wrong.
- Per student: starting level, highest level, lock a level, voice typing on or off.

Seeing progress

- Every typed answer goes into the Question Reports you already have, by game and by day, with tries and time.
- A ladder picture for each student: which level they are on, and their sentence path.
- A wall of the sentences they wrote themselves (levels 7 and 8), so you can read them and send a star.
- Words the app does not know are flagged for you to check.

7. Where it plays

Assignments and Quiz Mode: full screen, all 8 levels. This is the main home for it.

Inside games (the question pop-ups in Shape Dash, Supernature battles and the others): typing a whole sentence in the middle of a game is a big interruption, so I suggest games ask only levels 1 to 3 (one or two words). Question 4 asks what you want.

Later idea: a sentence a student writes at level 7 or 8 could play as a little movie on Grammar Gus's Pixel TV, as a reward that shows their own sentence coming to life.

8. How it would be built (after you say yes)

Phase	What
1	Your 43 sentences and 10 symbols in the app. The writing screen with levels 1 to 5, the checks, hints and read-aloud. The new set type with sentence and level picking. Works in Assignments and Quiz Mode. Typed answers in Question Reports.
2	Levels 6 to 8, the word lists that check "any word of the right kind", the live symbol lighting, and the wall of their own sentences.
3	Per-student ladder controls and the ladder picture. Games ask levels 1 to 3. Adding your own sentences. Optional voice typing.

9. Questions for you before I build

Each one has my suggestion in green. You can answer with just the numbers ("all yes", or "1 old shapes, 4 no games").

1. Which symbols? These new icons, or the colored shapes already in the Grammar Sandbox?

Suggestion: the new icons for this feature, since they match your cards and have the proper noun crown. Should the Grammar Sandbox and Grammar Gus switch to them too?

2. Which words count in a blank? Only your card's word, or any word of the right kind that makes sense?

Suggestion: at level 1 only your card's word (it is on a helper card). From level 2, any fitting word counts, and the screen then shows "Your card says: jumped."

3. Spelling. Exact spelling only, or allow one small slip?

Suggestion: allow one slip (two in long words), count it as right, and always show the correct spelling.

4. Games. Should game pop-ups ask these at all?

Suggestion: yes, but only levels 1 to 3.

5. Voice typing. Allow 🎤 say it, then type it?

Suggestion: off by default, and you switch it on per student.

6. Moving up and down.

Suggestion: up after 4 of the last 5 are right on the first try; after 3 misses in a row, offer a step down and let the student choose.

7. Their own sentences (levels 7 and 8). Checked by the app, or sent to you?

Suggestion: the app checks the pattern, the capital letter and the punctuation right away, and every one also lands on your wall to read. Unknown words are flagged for you.

8. Sentence order. Your numbers 1 to 43, or grouped by kind (pronouns, proper nouns, interjections)?

Suggestion: your numbers, with the short pronoun and proper noun cards mixed in early.

9. Rewards.

Suggestion: the same as other question sets, with whole-sentence levels (5 to 8) counting as two questions because they take longer.

10. Name. "Symbol Sentence Writer", or something else the students would like?